

How Does Social Media Affect Behaviour Regulation?

HS2911 Group 2
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“Viral”
“Brain Rot”
“Social Media”
“Doom-Scrolling”
“FYP”
“new content”
“Attention Span”

How does it affect us?

Why do we keep going back to our phones and social media?

01

Brief introduction to case study



Article

Impact of Social Media Engagement on Attention Span Among Young Adults: The Mediating Role of Fear of Missing Out

(Zahra et al., 2025)

Phenomenon

This article examines the phenomenon of shorter attention spans among individuals attributable to short-form videos on social media. More importantly, it explores why individuals, and youths in particular, engage in constant use.

- Examines key concerns about how social media affects cognitive skills, particularly the ability to maintain focus. This consequently affects memory strength and productivity.

Phenomenon

Short-form content sharing may prompt users to seek additional information, thereby making it more difficult for them to attend to long-term tasks promptly.

This urge to constantly engage is partly caused by the Fear of Missing Out (FoMO), which means having anxious thoughts that people, while you're away, are having good experiences. Another factor is the design of social media. This sustains a pattern of distraction and difficulty in paying attention.

When attention is fragmented, it may reduce a person's self-control and mental focus over the long term.

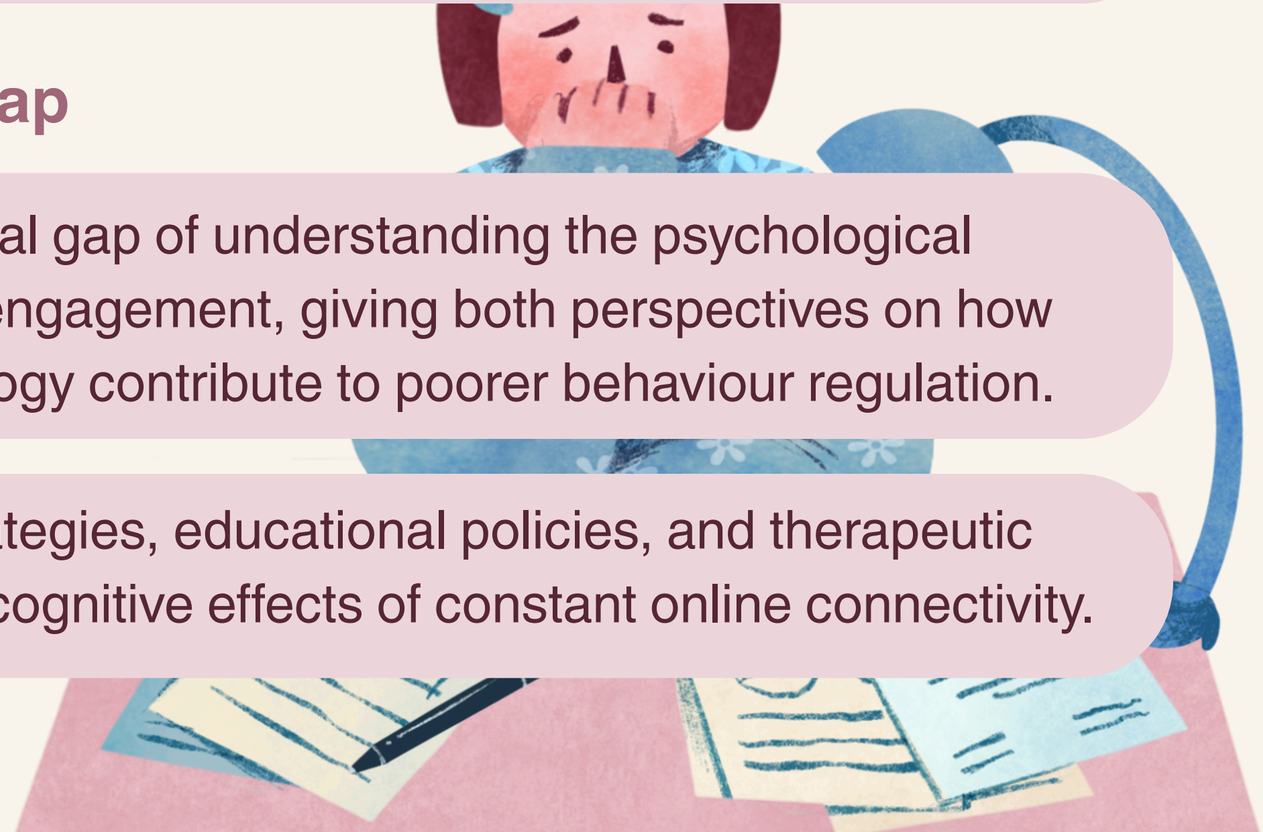
Importance of Phenomenon

The issue of shorter attention span not only reflects the concern of weakening focus and concentration, but also paints a larger phenomenon that social media is inflicting – poorer behaviour regulation. This is of high importance because the study not only found such effects on users with high engagement, but also on moderate users.

Gap

Additionally, this research fills in the critical gap of understanding the psychological mechanisms behind constant social media engagement, giving both perspectives on how platform affordances and one's own psychology contribute to poorer behaviour regulation.

The findings can inform digital wellness strategies, educational policies, and therapeutic interventions aimed at mitigating the adverse cognitive effects of constant online connectivity.



Contextual Background

02



Social media context

Which platforms does the phenomenon occur on?

1. TikTok, Instagram Reels, YouTube Shorts
2. Strongest on short-form, algorithm-driven platforms

What affordances are relevant?

1. Visibility - content and peer activity are constantly seen
2. Persistence - content remains accessible and resurfaces
3. Algorithm curation - personalised feed shapes exposure and attention
4. Immediacy - rapid, continuous delivery of new content

What typical user behaviours or norms shape this issue?

1. Habitual checking and prolonged scrolling
2. Expectation of constant connectivity
3. FoMO-driven engagement
4. Passive, continuous consumption

Mental health context

What mental health constructs are relevant?

1. Fear of Missing Out (FoMO) - drives compulsive engagement (mediator) (Zahra et al., 2025)
2. Attention regulation - poorer ability to sustain focus (outcome) (Yan et al., 2024) → This is not the same as boredom, it is the ability to sit through boredom or sustain their attention amidst mundane work (Pochmara, 2022)
3. Self-control - less able to resist immediate digital rewards (reduced behavioural regulation) (Yan et al. (2024), Runions (2013))
4. Problematic social media use - addictive tendencies (behavioural consequence) (Messena & Everri (2023), Khalaf et. al (2023))

How is mental health conceptualised or measured in the literature?

1. 10-item Likert-type FoMO Scale (developed by Przybylski et al.)
2. Mind Wandering Questionnaire (developed by Mrazek et al.)
3. Social Media Engagement Questionnaire (developed by Przybylski et al.)

Population context

Who is affected? (e.g. teens, activists, marginalised groups, content creators, general public)

- Young adults (digital natives)

03

Core Problem



RESEARCH QUESTION

How does social media affect behaviour regulation?

What features of social media decrease the individual's capacity for behaviour regulation?

What are the consequences of these social media effects on self-regulation?

What mediates the continued use of social media and consequently the regulation of behaviour?

How does social media affect behaviour regulation?

- Digital platforms for creating, sharing & interacting in real time
- e.g., Instagram, Tiktok, Youtube
- Communication tools & attention-driven systems → maximise user engagement
- Not a neutral platform
- Actively shape users' experience (i.e., interaction with information, duration spent on platform, frequency of return)

- One's ability to control, monitor & adjust actions
- Specific focus on attention span & self-control





RQ1: What features of social media decrease the individual's capacity for behaviour regulation?



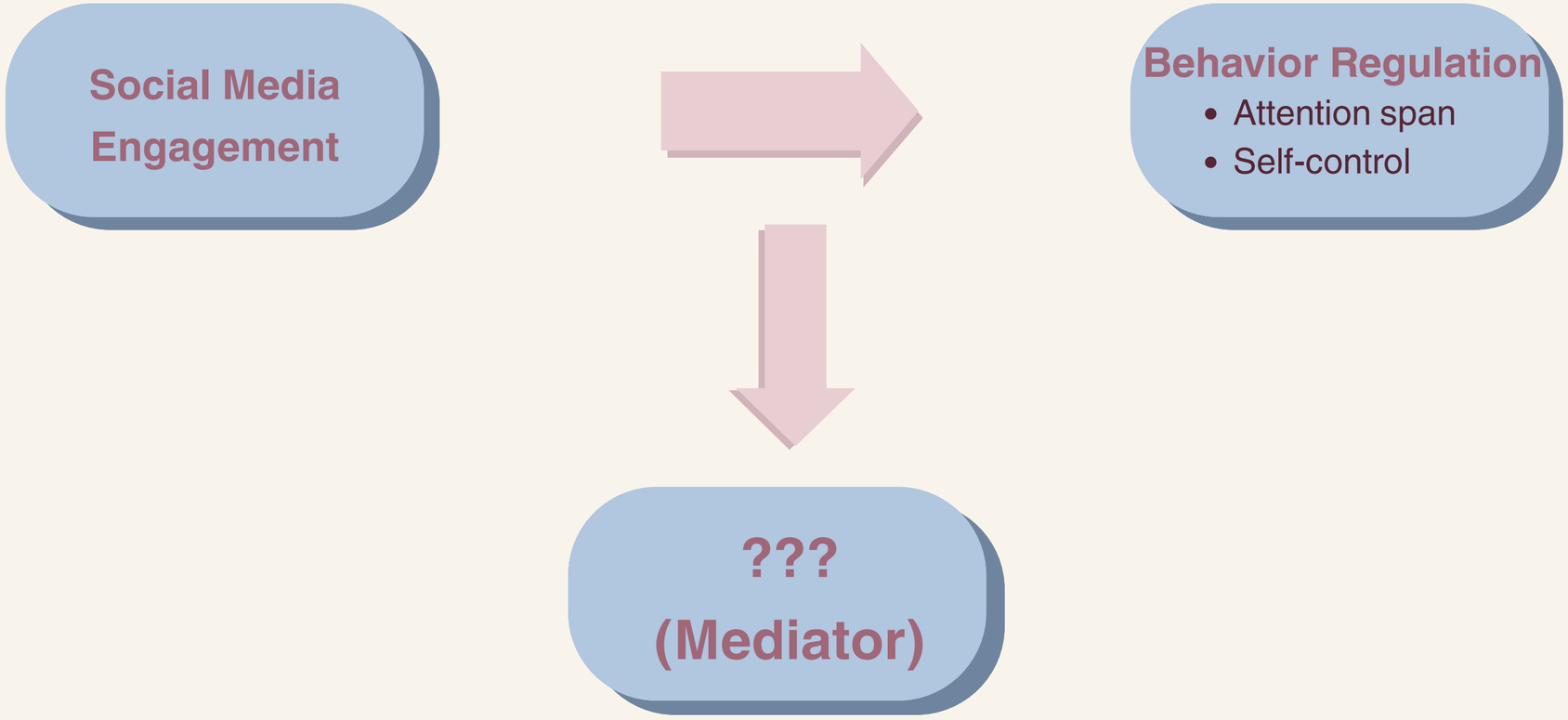
Social media platforms are designed for speed, convenience & constant engagement.

- **Design features:**

1. **Short-form content -** Users are trained to expect quick stimulation and instant gratification
2. **Infinite scrolling -** Users keep consuming content without actively deciding to continue
3. **Algorithmic feeds -** Users are bombarded with highly curated content relevant to them, making it harder to disengage

Overall, these features, paired with social media affordances mentioned earlier, reduce the need for active control over our actions.

RQ2: What mediates the continued use of social media and consequently the regulation of behaviour?



RQ3: What are the consequences of these social media effects on self-regulation?

- **Attention span**

Reduced due to constant exposure to fast, stimulating content. More difficult for individuals to focus on slower, more demanding tasks.

- **Self-control**

Weakened ability to resist checking one's phone. This is reinforced by the dopamine-driven feedback loops through likes, comments, and new content.



RATIONALE FOR RESEARCH QUESTIONS

- **INDIVIDUAL LEVEL** (e.g., young adults)

Difficulties in sustaining attention and regulating impulses can undermine learning and productivity.

- **COMMUNITY LEVEL**

Superficial information processing. More prone to fake news. Weakened public discourse.

- **PUBLIC HEALTH PERSPECTIVE**

Cognitive overload. Sleep disruption. Heightened stress.

- **PSYCHOLOGICAL EFFECTS**

Reduced concentration. Impaired executive functioning.

- **SOCIAL EFFECTS**

Diminished social engagement. Poorer communication quality.

- **BEHAVIOURAL EFFECTS**

Compulsive checking. Multitasking. Reduced persistence in goal-directed tasks.

04

Evidence from Research Literature



A Findings from the Main Case Study

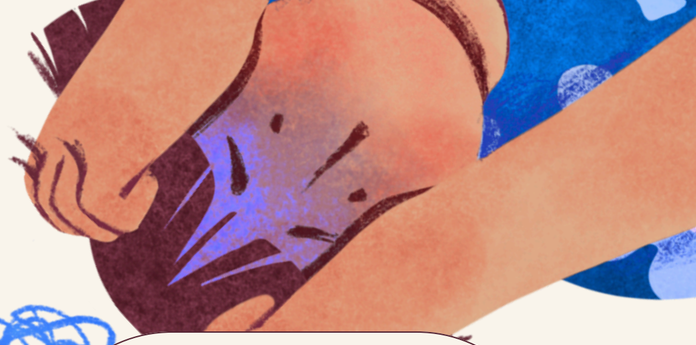
What did the authors discover?	• Higher levels of social media engagement was associated with higher levels of mind wandering • FoMO partially mediated the relationship between social media use and attention span
What methods were used?	• 220 young adults aged between 18 and 30 took part in an online survey
What are the key psychological or social outcomes?	• Higher levels of social media engagement is associated with increased levels of FoMO • Higher levels of social media engagement is associated with a decrease in attention span and self-control • Higher levels of social media engagement is associated with an increase in stress levels and fear of exclusion • Social media engagement and FoMO leads to lower academic achievements • FoMO leads to an increased reliance on social media validation

B External Evidence

Overview of readings







Theme 1: Effects of Social Media on Mental Health

- Broad positive and negative impacts of social media on mental health
- Effect of social media on Attention Span
- Children's relationship with digital technologies and its impact on their well-being

Theme 2: Platform Affordances that Amplify or Reduce Harm

- Affordances of Visibility, Editability, Persistence, and Association
- Affordances of specific platforms along with Short-form Videos
- Effect of Affordances on Behaviour Exhibitions

Theme 3: Mediating factors of social media use and mental health

- How FoMO Creates Online Vulnerability
- How FoMO decreases self-control, increasing social media use
- Studying the connection between attention span and lack of self-control

Theme 4: Possible Interventions

- Digital literacy and possible abstinence strategies
- Use of Machine Learning models for precision psychiatry (integration of AI into interventions)

External Evidence

Theme 1: Effects of Social Media on Mental Health

Reading 1: Unpacking the relation between children's use of digital technologies and children's well-being: A scoping review (Messena & Everri, 2023)

Summary of Reading:

The conceptualisation of this study was twofold: one concerned excessive/addictive use of devices of the Internet and of social media platforms; the other referred to the children's negative experiences or risky behaviours.

Main Findings:

1. The most considered finding was the interference of Internet use with daily life routines and tasks and the related disturbance of adaptive functions.
2. This is followed by compulsion/loss of control and concern, fears or worries related to not being able to access the Internet.

Link to our Research Topic:

This study showed a general drop in mental health of children when using social media frequently and it also revealed that the use of social media is positively correlated to the feelings of compulsion within children.

External Evidence

Theme 1: Effects of Social Media on Mental Health

Reading 2: The impact of social media on the mental health of adolescents and young adults: a systematic review (Khalaf et. al, 2023)

Summary of Reading:

The reading discussed about the positive and negative impacts of social media on adolescents and young adults.

Main Findings:

1. Positive impacts of social media: Boosts social connection with friends and family, increased feeling of community and the potential to improve adolescent mental health.
2. Negative impacts of social media: Higher levels of social networking are correlated with depression, poor sleep quality and unfavourable comparison between themselves and others.

Link to our Research Topic:

The study shows that social media have the ability to negatively affect behaviour regulation. Young people are more likely to engage in risky behaviour when exposed to information on social media that depicts risky behaviour. Social media also increases the risk of self-harm among at-risk adolescents.

External Evidence

Theme 1: Effects of Social Media on Mental Health

Reading 3: Mobile phone short video use negatively impacts attention functions: an EEG study. (Yan et. al, 2024)

Summary of Reading:

The study investigates the effect of short-form video use on attentional functions. The study looks into the adverse consequences that stem from short video consumption and emphasizes the importance of formulating interventions to mitigate short video addiction.

Main Findings:

1. An increase in consumption of short videos on mobile phone negatively impacts self-control.
2. The use of short video has negative impact on the neural processing of executive control.

Link to our Research Topic:

The study revealed that short-form videos is one of the features of social media that reduces individuals' capacity for behaviour regulation, specifically reduced self-control. The study also discussed the consequences of excessive consumption of short-form videos, such as social withdrawal and reduced interpersonal skills.

External Evidence

Theme 1: Effects of Social Media on Mental Health

Reading 4: Toward a Conceptual Model of Motive and Self-Control in CyberAggression: Rage, Revenge, Reward, and Recreation (Runions, 2013)

Summary of Reading:

The reading explores the relationship between exposure to social media and its consequent effect on the manifestation of reduced self-control in individuals in the form of aggressive behaviour

Main Findings:

1. Exposure and regulation: Social media (the internet never sleeps) → lack of sleep → sleep disturbances → irregular sleep patterns → fatigue → limited self-control → increased social media use
2. Sensation seeking and reduced self-control: Short-form videos → Affordances of perpetual audience and constant engagement → Shorter attention span/need to fill up “boredom” → need to find sensation → increased social media use

Link to our Research Topic:

The reading’s findings on aggression make an implicit link to one’s capacity for self-control, highlighting that social media not only increases trigger points to intense emotions, but also weakens the capacity for one to restrain them.

External Evidence

Theme 2: Platform Affordances that Amplify or Reduce Harm

Reading 5: Social Media Use in Organizations: Exploring the Affordances of Visibility, Editability, Persistence, and Association (Treem & Leonardi, 2016)

Summary of Reading:

Social media fosters these four affordances: visibility, persistence, editability, and association. Affordances are not just what the platform provides, but what the relationship between the user and the platform features provides and enables.

Main Findings:

1. Visibility: the ability to see information related to the status of ongoing activities
2. Persistence: there's an endless amount of content → further enables scrolling
3. Associations: connectivity afforded by social media can create a bridge between individuals, supplementing existing relationships → "Emergent Associations" (the tools helped people develop associations to others or information beyond the intentions of the original communicative act)

Link to our Research Topic:

The persistence and visibility of social media can also afford information seeking that does not require direct, interpersonal social interaction. The ability for a person to seek information passively through social media extends our RQ on how affordances enable FoMO too.

External Evidence

Theme 2: Platform Affordances that Amplify or Reduce Harm

Reading 6: Technology Affordances, Social Media Engagement, and Social Media Addiction: An Investigation of TikTok, Instagram Reels, and YouTube Shorts (Roberts & David, 2025)

Summary of Reading:

This study helps to show unique affordances offered by Short-form Videos (SFVs) that heighten social media engagement, and ultimately, lack of self-control.

Main Findings:

1. SFV platforms are designed to maintain user attention for as long as possible ON the platform → constant stream of stimulating content → increases users' drive for stimulation → decreases their attention span on more mundane, ordinary life things → FoMO in the virtual world
2. Affordances of SFVs → perceived effortlessness → Eg. users are served a continuous stream of highly personalised videos immediately after opening the app → enabled by an algorithm → double the speed of videos with a tap of a finger → simply swipe up to view the next video when bored → ease of use and persistence of content are important technology affordances in sustaining user attention

Link to our Research Topic:

Obsessive, repetitive cycle → the more you use, the more the algorithm knows and the more the algorithm knows how to feed you with content you crave → the more engaged you are on the phone, the less so in reality → lose that self-discipline to hold off on social media, as it is what provides constant gratification.

External Evidence

Theme 2: Platform Affordances that Amplify or Reduce Harm

Reading 7: Applying an affordances approach and a developmental lens to approach adolescent social media use (Moreno & Uhls, 2019)

Summary of Reading:

The study uses an affordance approach to understand the ways adolescents use social media and the various impacts associated with it.

Main Findings:

1. Social affordances: social media allows adolescents to feel a sense of belonging to a group and provides opportunities to develop social skills. However, this may also lead to cyberbullying.
2. Identity affordances: Social media allows adolescents to explore and experiment with their identities.
3. Cognitive affordances: Notifications from social media applications may disrupt adolescents' from focusing on their current activities.
4. Emotional affordances: social media helps generate empathy and allows for social comparison.

Link to our Research Topic:

The study revealed that online social comparison leads to FoMO in some adolescents, sustaining the continued use of social media. Comparison to unrealistic role models leads to frustration, reducing self-regulation.

External Evidence

Theme 3: Mediating factors of social media use and mental health

Reading 8: Adolescence and online vulnerability: The role of fear of missing out (FoMO): A cross-sectional study during the third wave of the COVID-19 pandemic (Giancola et al., 2025)

Summary of Reading:

The reading explores the relationship between the fear of missing out and an individual's sense of vulnerability online, which affects their self-control due to the presence of more extreme emotions.

Main Findings:

1. FoMO emerged as a key driver of problematic online behaviours among adolescents, including obsessive usage and inability to detach themselves from the online world
2. The greater the social media usage, the greater the FoMO, the higher the sense of online vulnerability, the weaker the self-control

Link to our Research Topic:

This supports the main case study's claim on FoMO being a key mediating factor, and adds to developing the argument that FoMO works as a mediating factor not only because of the anxiety that one is missing out on other people's activities, but because it is also self-reinforcing, as using social media does not reduce the sense of FoMO but increases it.

External Evidence

Theme 3: Mediating factors of social media use and mental health

Reading 9: The effect of social media addiction on attention span and aggression among university students. (Husain et al., 2024)

Summary of Reading:

The reading explores the relationship between social media addiction, attention span, and aggression among university students.

Main Findings:

1. Higher levels of social media engagement may hinder one's ability to fully focus, implying a reduction in attention span.
2. Higher levels of social media engagement, paired with passive consumption, may give rise to an increase in aggressive behaviours
3. Engaging in mindfulness training is associated with a reduction in engaging with aggressive behaviours

Link to our Research Topic:

The study highlights mindfulness training, which promotes a passive awareness of one's thoughts and emotions, as a potential intervention in reducing aggressive behaviours and improving the mental health of adolescents.

External Evidence

Theme 4: Interventions

Reading 10: Modern views of machine learning for precision psychiatry (Chen et al., 2022)

Summary of Reading:

The study assesses the use of Machine Learning (ML) models to assess social media consumption patterns and check who is at higher risk of mental health issues or exhibiting behaviours that may signal mental health issues.

Main Findings:

1. Digital interventions → an integration of medications, wearable devices, mobile health apps, social support, and online education, will be essential to improve mental health and assist therapeutic outcomes by providing personalised solutions
2. Telehealth services → provide access to professionals based on different mobile platforms, including text, voice, and video communication

Link to our Research Topic:

This can inform us of how to carry out intervention and enable better, more targeted responses to this new issue of shortening attention span and reduced self-control, which does not fall neatly into pre-existing remedies for mental health.

External Evidence

Theme 4: Interventions

Reading 11: The impact of social media use interventions on mental well-being: systematic review (Plackett et. al, 2023)

Summary of Reading:

The study investigates the effectiveness of various social media use interventions in improving mental well-being in adults. The interventions investigated are limited use, full abstinence and therapy-based.

Main Findings:

1. Therapy-based interventions were more effective than limiting use of social media or full abstinence from social media.
2. Depression was the most improved mental health outcome, with 70% of the studies that measured this outcome showing a benefit of the intervention.

Link to our Research Topic:

This study highlights therapy-based intervention as a possibly effective method to improve behavioural regulation and self-control, because therapy enables individuals to replace negative thoughts with structured goals and positive thinking.

C

Summary of Interpretation and Impact

Unpacking the research question

Recall:

How does social media affect behaviour regulation?

What features of social media decrease the individual's capacity for behaviour regulation?

What mediates the continued use of social media and consequently the regulation of behaviour?

What are the consequences of these social media effects on self-regulation?

1 Summary of Interpretation and Impact

Unpacking the research question

RQ1: What features of social media decrease the individual's capacity for behaviour regulation?

Broad Affordances: ***(Treem & Leonardi, 2013)***

1. Visibility: social media makes everything more visible despite not being physically able to witness or view it
2. Persistence: the ever-presence of content = there is always something happening, and you have the option to view it
3. Associations: excessive connectivity to both people and social media content → hyper-connectivity → increased FoMO

Specific Affordances: ***(Roberts & David, 2025), (Moreno & Uhls, 2019)***

1. Short-form videos: shorter exposure to content of a particular nature → greater quantitative exposure to new content → higher stimulation from various new topics → lower tolerance for in-depth exposure of one topic
2. Choice to speed up videos → further exacerbates point 1 on lower attention span → increases passive consumption → further decreases tolerance for slower content flow → repeated cycle where the need for more stimulation

2 Summary of Interpretation and Impact

Unpacking the research question

RQ2: What mediates the continued use of social media and consequently the regulation of behaviour?

Social Media Engagement

Frequent social media use can heighten FOMO by making individuals feel that others are constantly getting rewarding experiences without them.
(Giancola et al., 2025)

FoMO

Reduced Behavior Regulation

Passive use of social media further creates a division between the self and others, with the individual absorbing overwhelming information about others → reduces the capacity to feel certain about one's one life and become even more caught up in using social media to occupy one's own consciousness of thought.
(Husain et al., 2024)

3 Summary of Interpretation and Impact

Unpacking the research question

RQ3: What are the consequences of these social media effects on self-regulation?

Affordances of Social Media + FoMO as a mediating factor =

1. Lower attention span
2. Lower ability to focus
3. Weaker self-control
4. Compulsion to use social media

(Yan et al., 2024)

Heavy disruption of lifestyle due to constant feelings of missing out on other people's lives and the availability of social media to provide that buffer for people to consume as much engaging content as they can result in a decreased capacity for behaviour regulation.

(Messena & Everri, 2023)

Furthermore, prolonged excessive social media use can lead to other consequences on self-regulation, such as increased aggression, as their tolerance for slower and more mundane events is significantly reduced, meaning that their trigger points are a lot more pronounced.

(Khalaf et al., 2023), (Runions, 2013)

Interpretation and Impact

Similarities and Differences across readings

Similarities:

- The **affordances of social media** enable continued and increased platform engagement.
- The **mediating role of FoMO is relatively strong** in increasing social media usage and also decreasing mental well-being, associated with greater anxiety and uncertainty.

Differences:

- The **extent to which FoMO plays as a mediating role** differs with varying factors: Whilst our main case study (Hussain et al., 2025) states that FoMO affects moderate users of social media as much as extreme users, therefore making FoMO a highly influential factor, other readings like Khalaf et al (2023) and Giancola et al (2025) state that the effect of FoMO is greater on extreme users.
- **Age as a confounding factor** for high usage of social media: Giancola et al (2025) also found that the greater the age of adolescents, the more intense the feelings of FoMO are, and therefore the greater the usage of social media. On the other hand, Messena & Everri (2023) argue that the use of social media is positively correlated with younger ages because of the lower ability to self-restrain themselves compared to older individuals.



05

Implications or proposed directions

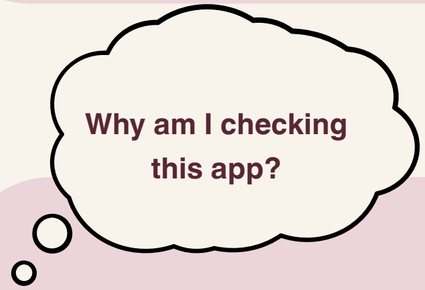


Implications for Mental Health

What should individuals, families, educators, or policymakers do to reduce harm and support well-being?

Individual Level

Promote healthy social media consumption habits, such as learning to critically engage with social media rather than passively consuming it.



Mindless Engagement VS Meaningful Interaction

Practice digital detox (Plackett et. al, 2023):

1. Full abstinence
2. Limiting the use of social media

- Structured routines (track screentime, use time-blocking technique, etc)
- Active > Passive social media usage

Implications for Mental Health

What should individuals, families, educators, or policymakers do to reduce harm and support well-being?

Families & Educators

Promote digital literacy and emotional awareness: Young adults must be more conscious of social media affordances that are designed to trigger FoMO and may lead to addiction.

Strengthen offline support systems:

- Create safe offline spaces for people to reduce dependence on online validation.
- Normalize offline conversations on personal distress to reduce online vulnerability and FoMO (Giancola et al., 2025).

Conduct therapy-based interventions (Plackett et. al, 2023): group psychological counseling (cognitive behavioral therapy) to facilitate regaining self-control through encouraging reflection on life priorities and focusing on social activities and relationships, which will improve attention span and well-being.

Implications for Mental Health

What should individuals, families, educators, or policymakers do to reduce harm and support well-being?

Policymakers

Incorporate digital well-being education in the school curriculum (Chen et al., 2022)

AI-based interventions:

- Integrating Machine Learning models into medications, wearable devices, and mobile health apps for precision psychiatry (Chen et al., 2022)
- Detection of harmful patterns of excessive engagement
- Alerts as a form of behavioral nudges.

Implications for Platforms

Which affordances hurt?

- Persistence → no stopping cues
- Algorithm curation → hyper-personalised feeds fuel addiction
- Immediacy → constant and rapid content delivery
- Visbility → reinforces social comparison and FoMO

Which affordances help?

- Interruptive cues (e.g. “You’ve been scrolling for 20 mins”)
- Content friction (e.g. pauses, load delays)
- Usage transparency (e.g. screen time insights)

How might interface design or content moderation play a role?

- Introduce natural stopping points (e.g. end-of-feed markers)
- Allow users to customise algorithm intensity
- Reduce autoplay/endless scroll features
- Implement “nudge” notifications to encourage breaks

This limits highly addictive/repetitive content loops, reduces emotionally manipulative/comparison-driven content and promotes balanced, meaningful content over passive consumption.

Implications for Research

What gaps remain?

This study heavily focused on FoMO as a mediating factor, neglecting other potential confounding factors (sociodemographic background, personality, cognitive styles, and online behaviours or social media consumption habits)

Should future work include new populations, methods, or platforms?

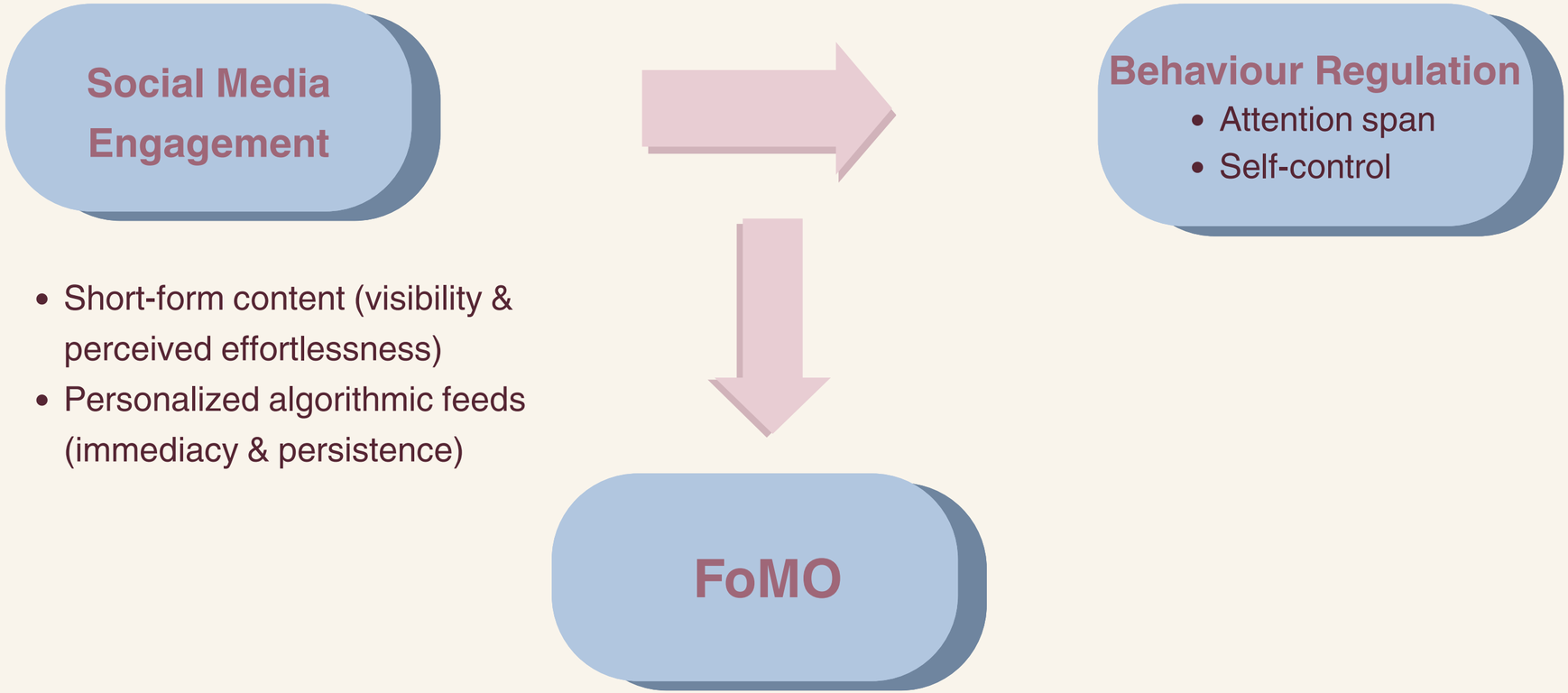
Future work should investigate deeper into how this phenomenon is observed on different social platforms, and whether users experience more FoMO on certain platforms more than others.

Furthermore, current studies mainly made use of self-reported data, which may contain bias. Therefore, future research should include cognitive tests to more objectively assess participants' sustained attention.



06

Conclusion



Social media affordances trigger FoMO, which mediates the relationship between social media engagement and behavior regulation

Among young adults, excessive use of social media may weaken behaviour regulation through reducing their attention span and impairing their ability to resist constant desires for stimulation.

Thank you!



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